

Brazil's Presidential Election Heads to a Run-Off

From: BBC News Mined: 2026-10-04 5 min read

Brazil's presidential election will be decided in a second round of voting on October 25. In the first round on Sunday, no candidate won more than 50 percent of the votes, which is what is needed to win outright.

Flávio Bolsonaro, a right-wing politician, finished first. He beat Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, the left-wing president who is now in office. Bolsonaro's result was better than many people expected. He is the son of former president Jair Bolsonaro, who is serving a 27-year prison sentence for leading a failed **coup** attempt after losing the last election. Jair Bolsonaro was not allowed to run again, so he backed his son.

Lula is 80 years old and is asking voters for a fourth term. He was first elected in 2002 and again in 2006, and he won a later term in 2022. After voting, he said the choice was between democracy and "barbarism." Bolsonaro, who is 45, said he wanted to "free the Brazilian people."

The campaign has divided the country again. Voters said top concerns included the economy, crime, corruption and Brazil's **independence** from other countries. Lula is more popular in the poorer northeast, among low-income voters, Catholics and women. Bolsonaro is more popular in the south and among wealthier voters and **evangelical** Christians.

During the campaign, Lula accused the United States of trying to influence Brazil's election. On Sunday, the head of Brazil's top **electoral court** said no evidence of international **interference** was found.

Brazil is the largest country and economy in Latin America. Most countries in the region now have right-wing leaders, so the **run-off** will help show whether Brazil follows that pattern.

Word Treasure

run-off -- A second round of voting between the top two candidates.

coup -- An attempt to take over a government by force.

evangelical -- A Christian group that stresses personal faith.

independence -- A country's freedom to make its own choices.

electoral court -- A court that oversees elections.

interference -- Trying to influence something that is not your business.

Break it down

Opening: the first round ends without a winner
The leading candidates and Jair Bolsonaro's sentence
What the candidates said after voting
A divided campaign and where each is popular
Claims about interference and the regional picture

Why it matters

The result will help decide who leads Latin America's largest country and shows how voters there feel about the economy, crime and corruption.

Test what you remember

1. What percent of votes does a candidate need to win outright?

- ☐ (A) Exactly 40 percent
- ☐ (B) About 67 percent
- ☐ (C) More than 50 percent
- ☐ (D) At least 25 percent

2. Which candidate is the son of a former president?

- ☐ (A) Michelle Bolsonaro
- ☐ (B) Lula da Silva
- ☐ (C) Flávio Bolsonaro
- ☐ (D) A court head

3. In what year did Lula first win election?

- ☐ (A) 2015
- ☐ (B) 2002
- ☐ (C) 2022
- ☐ (D) 2006

4. Where is Lula said to be more popular?

- ☐ (A) The poorer northeast
- ☐ (B) Outside Brazil
- ☐ (C) Only in the capital
- ☐ (D) The south

5. Which of these did voters name as a top concern?

- ☐ (A) School uniforms
- ☐ (B) Space travel
- ☐ (C) Brazil's independence from other countries
- ☐ (D) Sports funding

6. Why might the run-off show whether Brazil follows a regional pattern?

- ☐ (A) Brazil is the smallest country there
- ☐ (B) Brazil's neighbors hold elections on the same day
- ☐ (C) Most Latin American countries now have right-wing leaders
- ☐ (D) Lula has served in every country

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: B 4: A 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Lula: Said the choice was between democracy and "barbarism."
2. Flávio Bolsonaro: Said he wanted to "free the Brazilian people."
3. Brazil's top electoral court: Its head said no evidence of international interference was found.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):